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Traffic to the Moon



In April 2008, when the Indian Space Research Organisation launches Chandrayaan 1, the country's first Luna orbiter, it would have plenty of company at the moon. At the just-concluded International Astronautical Congress in Hyderabad, a full plenary session was devoted to discussing the space traffic headed to the moon. Only last month, Japan had successfully launched its lunar probe called Kaguya (Selene) that has just begun orbiting the moon. The Kaguya will study the moon's topography and gravity. By the end of the year China would have sent up up Chang'e-1, the first of its series of lunar orbiters. Named after a young fairy in Chinese fables that visited the moon, Chang'e-1 would test the technology needed for China's future missions to the moon.

So by the time Chandrayaan-1 gets to the moon it would have to co-ordinate its orbital slot to ensure that it does not collide with the Japanese and Chinese probes. Chandrayaan-1 is expected to orbit the moon for around two years and will be used to provide a high resolution map of the moon apart from searching for minerals and even water ice on the surface. It will also carry with it a lunar-impactor that will detach itself from the orbiter and penetrate the lunar surface at a predetermined spot. Chandrayaan-1 will be carrying a NASA scientific payload—the moon mineralogical mapper—making it one of the most talked about probes. It will be carrying a range of X-ray spectrometers for the European Space Agency to measure among other things the solar flux on the moon. ISRO Chairman G. Madhavan Nair says: "There is a renewed interest in lunar missions and India wants to be in the forefront of it."

Later in 2008, NASA would also be sending its own probe called the Lunar Reconnaissance Orbiter—the first of its Robotic Lunar Exploration Programmes that are designed to map the surface of the moon. With NASA deciding to resume manned missions to the moon, the series of orbiters would be used to determine future landing sites for them. The last time they sent a manned mission to land on the moon was the Apollo 17 in 1972. Now the American agency has chalked out ambitious plans not only to send humans to the moon once again but also to use the lunar surface as a major base to eventually send a manned mission to Mars. NASA chief Michael Griffin aptly described it as an effort "to build a space civilisation for tomorrow and beyond".



RANJAN RAHI

CONVICTED: Ex-MPs
Anand and wife Lovely



Sounding the Death-knell

PATNA The long arm of the law finally caught up with former MPs Anand Mohan and his wife Lovely. Almost 13 years after the heinous killing of the then Gopalganj (Bihar) district magistrate G. Krishnaiah, a Patna court convicted Mohan and his wife for the murder. Also convicted were controversial JD(U) MLA Vijay Kumar Shukla alias Munna Shukla and former MLA Akhlaq Ahmad. Twenty-nine other accused were acquitted for lack of evidence.

Krishnaiah, a 1985 batch Bihar cadre IAS officer, was killed by a mob led by the accused near Muzzaffarpur on December 5, 1994. The son of a construction worker in Andhra Pradesh, Krishnaiah was returning to his district of posting after attending a government meeting in Hajipur. "The verdict took too long to come," says Uma Krishnaiah, wife of the slain officer. "But I'm happy that justice has been done."

The mob that had congregated for the

funeral procession of local don Chhotan Shukla (elder brother of Munna Shukla)—who was murdered a day before by his rivals—intercepted Krishnaiah's vehicle, pulled him out and shot him dead. According to the prosecution, Anand and Lovely, then the Vaishali MP, were leading the procession. The verdict has sealed the fate of the politicians who face disqualification from contesting future elections after being sentenced. On his way to Beur central jail, Anand said he would contest the verdict in a higher court.

Anand rose to prominence when he became an MLA in the early '90s. He later won the parliamentary election in 1996 largely thanks to his Robin Hood image among his caste men. He is an accused in as many as 28 cases, has been convicted in one case and has secured acquittal in 20 cases. The sentence may sound the death-knell for Anand and Lovely's political ambitions.

by Amitabh Srivastava